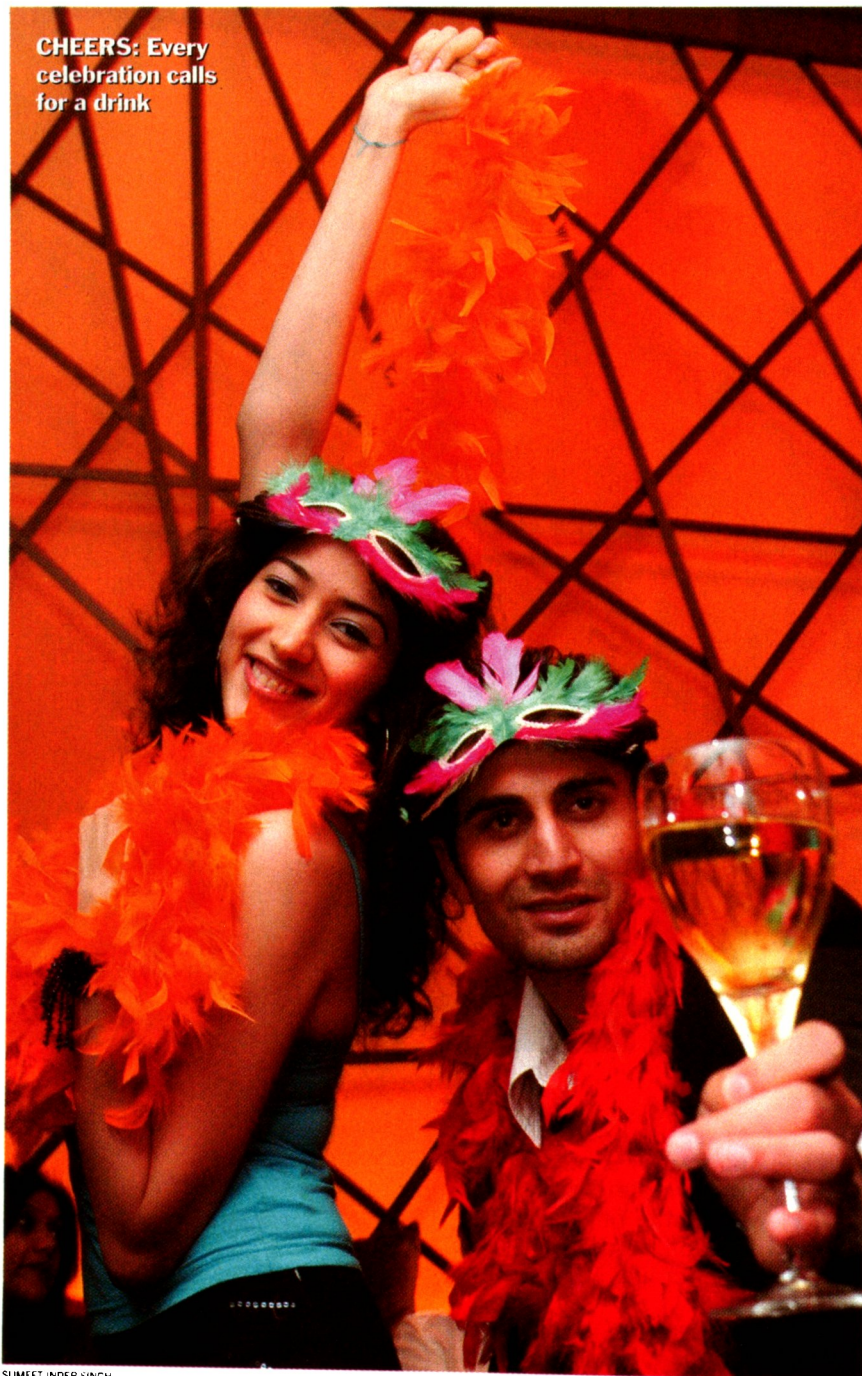


THE GUZZLERS' PARADISE

Thanks to a growing tribe of young professionals, rising affluence and easy availability, alcohol consumption is at a new high in India

CHEERS: Every celebration calls for a drink



SUMET INDER SINGH

■ By Malini Bhupta

Celebrating India's scintillating victory in the Twenty20 World Cup surely demands popping the best bubbly or sipping the best Scotch whisky. But gone are the days when the 'best' was reserved only for such spectacular occasions. Now even the most mundane events are being celebrated with the best spirits and India's hippest metros—Mumbai, Delhi and Bangalore—are on a roll. Be it business meetings or weddings, it's all happening over a flute of champagne. It is said that the state of an economy can be judged by the performance of its champagne market. By that, India's economy is certainly sparkling as the champagne market today stands at 20,000 cases—10 per cent of the total wine market in the country, high duties and taxes notwithstanding—from 3,000-4,000 cases in 2001.

With growing affluence and easy availability, Indians are fast becoming connoisseurs of the finest malts, wines and vodkas. Limited edition whiskies and fine wines are a big hit with the new experimental India, which is witnessing a steady rise in alcohol consumption, like most other consumer products, at a steady clip of 15 per cent annually. The overall consumption of spirits touched a record 150 million cases in 2007, while beer totted up a 137 million cases in the same period—a growth of over 30 per cent over the previous year.

Explains Jeetesh Kaprani, food and beverage manager at The Oberoi, Mumbai: "Liquor consumption has grown and it's mainly due to the rising influence of clubs and the willingness of the younger generation to experiment. While all spirits are popular, the young prefer white spirits like vodka."

With 60 per cent of the country's population under 25 years of age and a significant number joining the workforce, almost 50 crore adults have entered the age of drinking. Says Debashish Shyam, assistant vice-president of United Spirits: "In about three to five years, the market will see huge volume growth, which is why white spirits are shooting up at over 40 per cent as it is considered the drink of the youth."